Literature Review

Mental Health Support App Prototype for Students using Figma

Course: Technical and Business Writing (TBW)
Instructor: Ms. Nazia Imam

Group Members:

Taha Ahmed (23k-0534)
Umar bin Abid (23k-0009)
Furqan Hilari (23k-0556)
Sarim Ali (23k-0048)
Tuaha Ahmed (23k-0713)
Sobaan Nayaar (23k-0893)

FAST National University of Computer and Emerging Sciences
Karachi Campus

1 Literature Review

Mental health issues among university students have become a major global concern in recent years. Increasing academic pressure, financial challenges, and social adjustments contribute to rising levels of stress, anxiety, and depression. Research shows that a significant number of students experience psychological distress during their academic journey, yet many do not seek professional help due to stigma, lack of awareness, or limited access to counseling services [1, 2]. This gap highlights the urgent need for alternative and more accessible solutions that can support students effectively.

1.1 Mental Health Challenges in University Students

University students face a unique combination of academic and personal pressures that negatively impact their mental well-being. Studies indicate that students often struggle with time management, academic workload, and social isolation. The transition to university life requires adaptation to new environments and expectations, which increases stress levels significantly. Additionally, competitive academic environments and expectations of high performance further contribute to emotional strain.

Many students hesitate to seek help due to fear of judgment, lack of trust in traditional support systems, or limited awareness about available resources. Cultural factors and social stigma surrounding mental health also discourage open discussion, leading to untreated psychological issues. As a result, there is a growing need for solutions that are private, accessible, and student-friendly [3].

1.2 Emergence of Digital Mental Health Solutions

With the advancement of technology, digital mental health applications have emerged as a practical and scalable solution to address these challenges. Mobile health (mHealth) applications provide features such as mood tracking, self-assessment tools, guided therapeutic exercises, and journaling options. These applications allow users to access mental health support anytime and anywhere, making them particularly suitable for university students.

Research suggests that such applications can help reduce symptoms of anxiety and depression while promoting emotional awareness and self-regulation. Furthermore, the flexibility and affordability of digital platforms make them an attractive alternative to traditional therapy, especially for students who may not have access to professional services. The increasing use of smartphones further supports the adoption of such solutions [4, 5].

1.3 Limitations of Existing Applications

Despite their potential benefits, many existing mental health applications face challenges related to user engagement and long-term retention. Poor usability, lack of personalization, and complex interfaces often discourage users from continued usage. Applications that are difficult to navigate can increase cognitive load, especially for users already experiencing stress or anxiety.

Another major limitation is the lack of emotional connection and personalization within many applications. Generic features may not address the specific needs of students, such as academic stress or time management challenges. As a result, many users abandon these platforms shortly after initial use, reducing their overall effectiveness [2]. This highlights the need for improved design strategies that prioritize usability and engagement.

1.4 Role of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI)

Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) plays a crucial role in improving the usability and effectiveness of digital mental health applications. Systems designed with HCI principles focus on simplicity, clarity, and user satisfaction. In the context of mental health, it is important to design interfaces that are supportive, intuitive, and easy to use.

A well-designed interface reduces cognitive load and ensures that users can interact with the system without confusion or frustration. Visual hierarchy, consistency, and accessibility are key components that enhance user experience. Applications that incorporate these principles are more likely to achieve higher levels of engagement and user satisfaction [6]. Therefore, HCI serves as a foundational element in designing effective mental health solutions.

1.5 User-Centered Design Approach

User-Centered Design (UCD) emphasizes the involvement of users throughout the development process. By understanding user needs, preferences, and behaviors, developers can create applications that are more effective and user-friendly. This approach ensures that the final product aligns with real-world user expectations and addresses practical challenges faced by students.

UCD involves continuous feedback, testing, and iteration, which leads to improved usability and better overall design quality. In mental health applications, this approach is particularly important because user comfort, accessibility, and emotional safety are critical factors. Applications designed using UCD principles tend to achieve higher user satisfaction and retention rates [7].

1.6 Use of Figma in Prototyping

Figma is a widely used design tool that enables the creation of interactive prototypes for digital applications. It allows designers to visualize ideas, test usability, and gather feedback before actual development begins. This helps in identifying design flaws early and reducing development costs.

The iterative design process supported by Figma allows continuous improvement based on user feedback. Designers can quickly modify layouts, test different features, and refine the user interface. Additionally, Figma supports real-time collaboration, allowing multiple stakeholders to contribute to the design process. This collaborative and flexible approach makes Figma an effective tool for developing user-centered mental health applications [8].

References

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